

EU DIGITAL SOVEREIGNTY



Who Really Controls European Citizens' Data?

DRC Summer School 2026 · EU36: Imagining Europe's Future
Democracy & Disinformation · Regensburg, July 2026

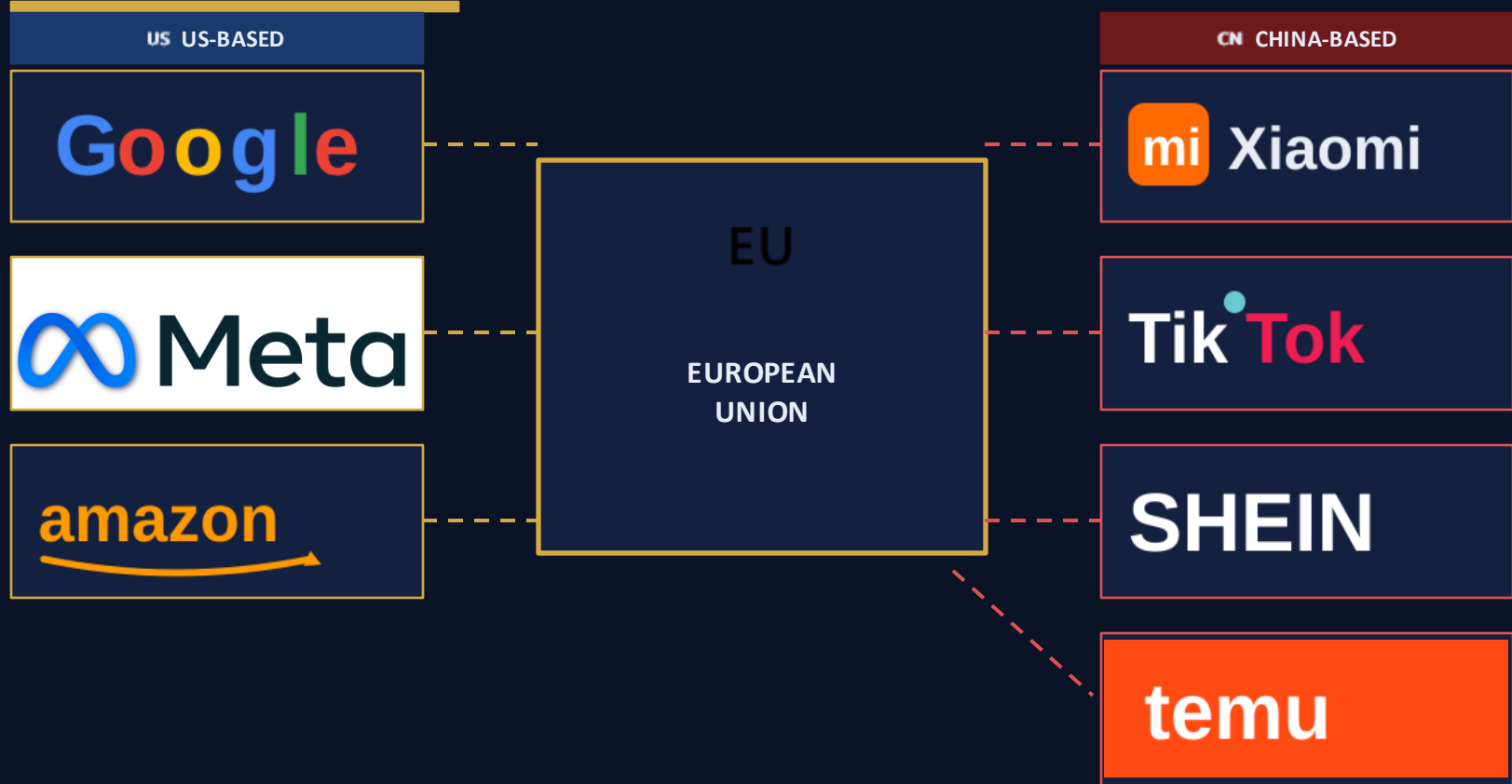
EU DATA IS OUT OF EU



THE PROBLEM

Billions of Europeans' personal data is being collected, sold, and exploited by foreign tech companies — without most people knowing or consenting.

WHO IS SURVEILLING



WHAT ARE THEY WATCHING

Every aspect of digital life:



IDENTITY

Name · Email · Phone



LOCATION

Live GPS · Travel History



HEALTH

Medical Records · Biometrics



FINANCE

Transactions · Financial
Behaviour



POLITICAL

Views · Associations · Votes



BIOMETRIC

Face ID · Fingerprints

HOW BIG IS THIS SURVEILLANCE?

~1.5B+

EU users tracked across all platforms
combined

~35 PB

Data generated per day from EU users
(analyst estimates)

6

Foreign companies with access to EU
citizens' most sensitive data

Data/day figures are analyst estimates based on user activity models

SURVEILLANCE BY THE NUMBERS

COMPANY	EU USERS	DATA / DAY	JURISDICTION
Google	~447M	~20 PB/day	CLOUD Act (USA) US
Meta (FB/IG/WA)	~545M	~5 PB/day	CLOUD Act (USA) US
Amazon	~200M+	~3.5 PB/day	CLOUD Act (USA) US
TikTok (ByteDance)	~175M	~3 PB/day	PIPL + NSL (China) CN
Shein, Temu	~105M+	~2.5 PB/day	PIPL + NSL (China) CN
Xiaomi	~100M+ (devices)	~0.8 PB/day	PIPL + NSL (China) CN

FOREIGN LAWS

US

CLOUD Act — USA (2018)

Allows the US government to demand access to data held by any American company, anywhere in the world. No EU warrant needed. No notification to the user.

CN

PIPL — China (2021)

China's data law. Requires Chinese companies to hand over data to the state on national security grounds. No refusal permitted.

CN

NSL — China (2020)

National Security Law. Extends Beijing's authority over any company with Chinese ties, wherever they operate.

THE JURISDICTION PROBLEM

A company based in a foreign country, dealing with your EU data, is forced to comply with its own government's law FIRST — then EU laws.

US US SCENARIO

- 1 You use Gmail in Paris
- 2 Data stored in Ireland (EU soil)
- 3 US Dept of Justice requests it
- 4 Google must comply

CN CHINA SCENARIO

- 1 You use TikTok in Berlin
- 2 ByteDance is a Chinese company
- 3 Chinese gov requests it
- 4 ByteDance must comply

WHY THIS IS A DEMOCRATIC ISSUE

Data control = narrative control = political power



Disinformation at Scale

Algorithmic amplification by foreign platforms shapes political narratives, elections, and public trust across Europe — outside EU democratic oversight.



Surveillance & Profiling

Detailed behavioural profiles built from EU citizens' data can be exploited by foreign state actors for targeted influence operations.



Asymmetric Power

European democracies depend on US infrastructure (AWS, Azure, Google Cloud) for government services, healthcare, and elections — a structural vulnerability.



Sovereignty Gap

Without control over data infrastructure, the EU cannot fully enforce its own laws or protect democratic processes from external interference.

"They no longer send armies. They just send algorithms to shape your citizens' opinions — based on their values, for their profit."

GDPR: THE FRAMEWORK

Core Principle: Your personal data belongs to YOU — not to the company that collects it.

Access

Ask any company what data they hold on you

Rectification

Correct inaccurate personal data

Erasure

"Right to be forgotten" — demand deletion

Portability

Receive your data in a usable format

Object

Refuse targeted ads and profiling

Restriction

Limit how your data is processed

Passed: 25 May 2018 · Applies globally to any company processing EU residents' data

GDPR IS NOT ENOUGH: ENFORCEMENT GAPS



Slow Enforcement

Cases drag on for years. Meta's WhatsApp fine took 3 years to resolve. Meanwhile, data flows uninterrupted.



Insufficient Penalties

4% of global turnover sounds large — but for trillion-dollar companies, fines are a cost of doing business, not a deterrent.



Regulatory Fragmentation

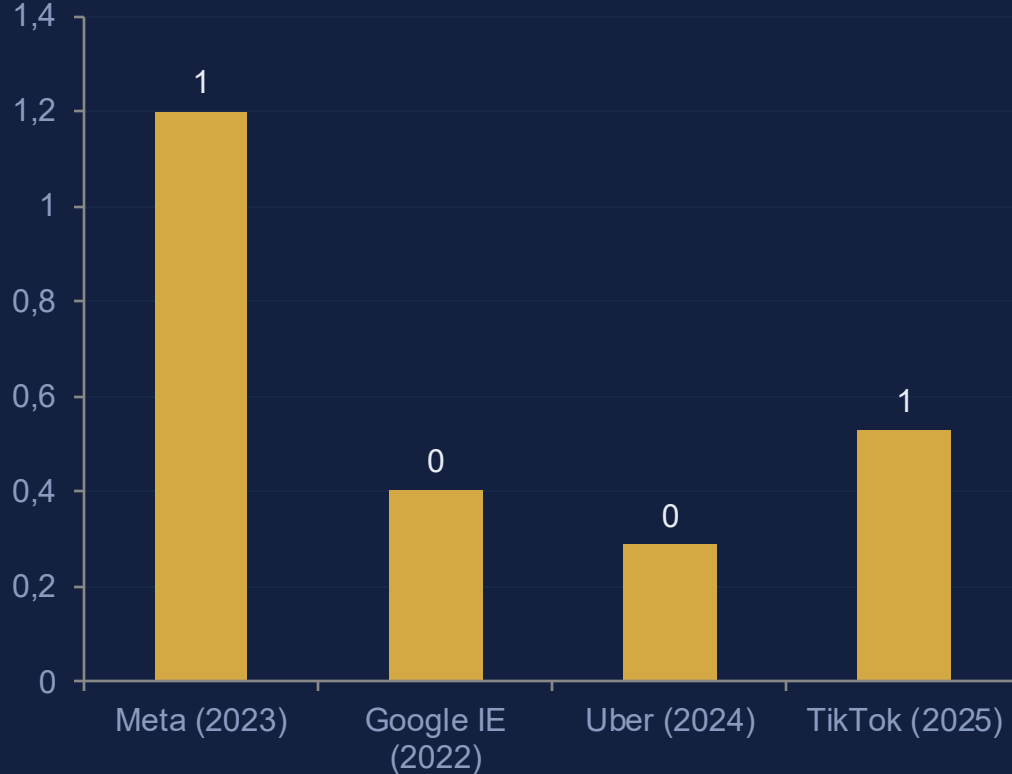
27 EU member states, 27 data protection authorities. Inconsistent enforcement creates arbitrage opportunities.



Cross-Border Transfers

Data flows to US and Chinese servers under frameworks (EU-US DPF) that remain legally contested and politically fragile.

GDPR FINES: BIG NUMBERS, SMALL DETERRENCE



€1.2B

Largest single GDPR fine ever (Meta, 2023)

€530M

Largest fine of 2025: TikTok for unlawful EU-China transfers

~0.1%

Meta fine as % of 2023 revenue (~\$117B) — "like a speeding ticket for a Formula 1 car"

€7.1B

Total GDPR fines since 2018 — across 2,800+ cases

THE ROAD TO RECLAIM DIGITAL SOVEREIGNTY

What Institutions Must Do

1



Escalating fines

Penalties that grow with repeat violations, not flat percentages



Data localisation

EU citizen data must be stored on EU soil



Invest in EuroCloud

Fund GAIA-X as sovereign European cloud infrastructure



Algorithmic transparency

Companies must disclose how recommendation systems work



DPA cooperation

No more regulatory shopping for the weakest enforcer



Fix the CLOUD Act conflict

Push for binding international data agreements

THE ROAD TO RECLAIM DIGITAL SOVEREIGNTY

What You Can Do Today

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Switch to EU alternatives

ProtonMail, Wire, Tresorit, Qwant
— choose European over
US/Chinese platforms



Exercise your GDPR rights

Request, correct, or delete your
data from any company — it's your
legal right



Review privacy settings

Opt out of data sharing and
targeted advertising wherever
possible



Vote with your choices

Support politicians and policies
that prioritise digital rights



Stay digitally literate

Understanding how your data is
used is the first line of defence



Demand accountability

Pressure platforms and
governments — public opinion
shapes regulation

CONCLUSION

***"To be free, therefore, one must be
feared.
And to be feared, one must be powerful."***

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